Lent 5A
The raising of Lazarus and communion

John 11:1-45

Opening Prayer

Sisters and brothers,
as Jesus, in the days before his passion,
offered prayers and supplications with loud cries and tears,
let us pray for those who suffer, those who are in need,
and those who seek reconciliation.
.....
God of compassion,
you know our faults and yet you promised to forgive.
Keep us in your presence and give us your wisdom.
Open our hearts to gladness,
call dry bones to dance,
and restore to us the joy of your salvation. Amen.
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Hymn: Rescue the Perish

Rescue the perishing, care for the dying,
snatch them in pity from sin and the grave;
weep o'er the erring one, lift up the fallen,
tell them of Jesus the mighty to save.

Refrain:
Rescue the perishing, care for the dying;
Jesus is merciful, Jesus will save.

Rescue the perishing, duty demands it—
strength for your labor the Lord will provide;
back to the narrow way patiently win them,
tell the poor wand'rer a Savior has died. [Refrain]

'Down in the human heart, crushed by the tempter,
feelings lie buried that grace can restore;
touched by a loving heart, wakened by kindness,
cords that are broken will vibrate once more. [Refrain]

Window of Wonder
"I shall live forever and ever and ever ' he cried grandly. 'I shall find out thousands and thousands of things. I shall find out about people and creatures and everything that grows - like Dickon - and I shall never stop making Magic. I'm well I'm well."

— Frances Hodgson Burnett, The Secret Garden

Creative Response: Communion Meal

You may like to find something to eat and drink for communion together.

Closing Prayer

God of all consolation and compassion,
your Son comforted the grieving sisters, Martha and Mary;
your breath alone brings life
to dry bones and weary souls.
Pour out your Spirit upon us,
that we may face despair and death
with the hope of resurrection
and faith in the One
who called Lazarus forth from the grave. Amen.
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Devotion - The Raising of Lazurus

Without doubt, our Lenten story today, the raising of Lazarus, is one of Jesus' greatest miracles. John presents it as the final and greatest sign, completing a series of seven signs that begins with the turning of water into wine, pointing ahead to the ultimate sign of Jesus' divinity; His own death and resurrection.
In John's Gospel we journey from Jesus turning water into wine at the wedding feast of Cana to the bitter vinegar wine that Jesus tasted at the cross before he said, "It is finished", then bowed his head, and gave up his spirit.
As we come back to the story of Lazarus, Jesus finally arrived at the tomb of Lazarus after four days. This means that Lazarus was dead beyond doubt and Martha, his sister says to Jesus, "Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died. But I know that even now, God will give you whatever you ask." These were desperate words of grief and faith. Then Jesus replied, "Your brother will rise again." Martha took this to mean the general resurrection of the last day, first mentioned clearly at Daniel 12:2 in the Old Testament, of which she had no doubt. Then Jesus replied, "I am the resurrection and the life. The one who believes in me will live, even though he should die; and whoever lives by believing in me, will never die. Do you believe this?"
Finally, Jesus came to the tomb of Lazarus, and he wept. His tears show us his humanity, compassion, love, and feeling. Jesus experienced the sorrow and grief that sin and death bring to this world and was aware of all that He was about to do. Jesus called out with a loud voice, "Lazarus, come out!" Lazarus then emerged, with burial clothes still attached to his hands and feet, as well as to his face. Jesus then said to them, "Take off the grave clothes, and let him go." In this way, Lazarus' sisters would experience with their own touch and hands, the great reality of resurrection, as this will one day apply to all who look forward to Jesus' coming again.

And as we come to the communion table of our Lord Jesus Christ, we too are invited to experience the reality of our Lord's death through the handling of the elements of bread and wine, symbols of immortality, which symbolise Jesus' broken body given for us, as well as his shed blood, poured out for us.
In John's Gospel, the cross is where God's glory is seen most clearly. It is the place where heaven and earth meet, and where Jesus, lifted up on the cross, draws all people to himself (John 12:32). For John, the cross is like a powerful magnet or a bright light, drawing people to Jesus through God's great expression of love.
The story of Lazarus reminds us that Jesus is not unmoved by our pain, tears, loss, and sorrow, and that is precisely why He finally went to the cross, and rose again from the dead, that we too might have hope, and live again. Jesus is the only one who could ever say, "I am the Resurrection and the Life", and "I am the Light of the world, so that no one who believes in me should stay in darkness", for these truths were demonstrated through the life-transforming power of his words and deeds; and so the symbols that we now share in, in remembrance of the death of Christ, are light, life, healing, truth, and hope, and they draw us to himself as we take part in them.
At 1 Corinthians 11:23-26, Paul reminds us of these words. "For I received from the Lord what I also passed on to you. The Lord Jesus, on the night he was betrayed, took bread, and when he had given thanks, he broke it and said, "This is my body, which is for you; do this in remembrance of me."
In the same way, after supper, he took the cup saying, "This cup is the New Covenant in my blood; do this, whenever you drink it, in remembrance of me."
For whenever you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the lord's death until he comes.

Prayer.
Let us now pray. Our Father in Heaven, we give you thanks for your great love expressed toward us, in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ. We thank you that we can touch and taste of the emblems of bread and wine, as vivid reminders of the promise of our future life in Christ as our resurrection and life everlasting. May the light of Jesus continue to guide us through this sin darkened world, and may the light of Christ continue to shine in dark places, changing our world for the better, as in his light, people may continue to see light, and experience truth and life more abundant and free. These things we ask, giving you thanks in the name of Jesus Christ. Amen.

Rev Dr Ted Woods.